in a hotel close to Carlyle Hotel on East 76th Street, where the prime minister and members of her delegation were to stay.

‘An honour to us’

Soon after my arrival, I started calling my relatives, friends and contacts spread across Canada and the US one by one, and that process continued till the end of Indira Gandhi’s visit. What I learnt was that although anti-Indira and anti-Congress feelings were running high among a segment of the Sikh diaspora due to the happenings in Punjab, there was nothing to support apprehensions of a threat to her life during that visit.

Some of the contacts, however, did ask me what had happened to their suggestions given to me during my December 1981 visit. According to them, rather than the situation improving, things were getting gradually worse as Hindu-Sikh relations had been vitiated further and some Sikhs were even suspected of nursing pro-Khalistan feelings. I didn’t have any clear answer to that, other than to say that I had passed on their suggestions to the concerned authorities and it may take some time before the situation improved.

The prime minister’s delegation reached New York on the afternoon of 27 July. After a formal reception at the airport, she drove straight to the Carlyle Hotel. The Indian delegation had a full complement of a VVIP security team from the Intelligence Bureau, led by Joint Director S.C. (Subhash) Tandon (IPS 1952 Rajasthan, later commissioner of Delhi Police, from April 1983 to 12 November 1984, including the period of the anti-Sikh pogrom in Delhi), his two deputy directors – S.D. Trivedi (IPS 1960 Uttar Pradesh) and my batchmate and friend Ratan Sahgal (IPS 1964 Madhya Pradesh) – and their supporting staff.

During her stay at New York, Indira Gandhi’s itinerary included a visit to the Metropolitan Museum on 28 July to attend the inauguration of an exhibition on India, followed by lunch. On her way to the hotel, a brief meeting with UN Secretary General Javier Perez de Cuellar was scheduled. The same afternoon, she was to leave for Washington on a two-day visit, for meetings with